

The interview that finds the person, and the first month that keeps children safe.

Schedule 2 of the Children's Homes (England) Regulations 2015 lists six things every staff file must hold: proof of identity with a photograph, the DBS certificate, two written references including the most recent employer, verification of why any earlier work with children or vulnerable adults ended, evidence of qualifications, and a full employment history with a satisfactory written explanation of any gaps. An interview record is not one of the six; it is good practice, and Ofsted's recruitment guidance expects interviews to be recorded. This page is the interview worth recording, then the first month.

The interview: questions that find the person

Before anyone speaks

Two people on the panel, one of them trained in safer recruitment. The application form in front of you with every job dated month and year, because the form is where the gaps show and the interview is where they get explained.

Good practice throughout this page means practice Ofsted's guidance on recruiting staff describes, not a rule in the regulations. The regulation is named where there is one.

Values and judgment

"Why do you want to work with these children, and what do you think the hardest part will be?"

"Tell me about a time a child or young person was angry with you. What did you do, and what did you feel?"

"Describe a boundary you found hard to hold. What did you do?"

"What would you do if you saw a colleague do something you thought was wrong? Would you tell someone outside the home, and who?"

"A child tells you something and asks you to keep it a secret. What do you say?"

"What does good recording look like at the end of a shift?"

The three probes, every time

Every gap (Schedule 2, item 6). Go through the form month by month. Each gap gets the question, "What were you doing then?", and their answer is recorded in their words. Where they are unsure, record that. Where the account does not fit the rest of the history, ask again and follow it up; the regulation asks for a satisfactory explanation, not just a written one. Never write it for them.

Every ending. "Why did that job end?" Then, "Would your last manager say the same?" Reasons that shift under the second question are the ones to check in the reference call.

Work with children or vulnerable adults that ended (Schedule 2, item 4). Verify, as far as practicable, why any such work ended. Ask it directly and write the answer.

The self-declaration question

Care roles are regulated activity, so an enhanced DBS check with the barred list applies, but you may only ask about what the law lets you take into account. Protected convictions and cautions, the ones filtered out by the DBS rules, must not be asked about or considered. The DBS self-declaration wording:

"Do you have any convictions, cautions, reprimands or final warnings that are not protected as defined by the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974 (Exceptions) Order 1975 (as amended in 2013 and 2020)?"

Tell the applicant they can check what counts as protected in the DBS filtering guidance at gov.uk (search "DBS filtering guide") before answering, and that a declaration is not a bar: anything declared is considered against the role. Record the answer, and what you decided and why.

What goes in the file

The date, who interviewed, the questions asked, a summary of the answers, the judgment and the reasons for it, signed by the panel. Plus the written gap explanations (Schedule 2, item 6) and the reference verification notes when the calls are made. Two written references are the Schedule 2 requirement; the phone verification is good practice.

Signs worth a second look

Reluctance or vagueness about a gap, or a different reason each time it comes up.

Every previous employer was the problem.

No reflection on boundaries, or an answer about boundaries that is all about the adult's feelings.

Over-interest in a particular child, age group or in being alone with children.

A reference from a mobile number or a friend rather than the organisation.

None of these decides anything on its own. Each one is a reason to ask one more question and to make the reference call to the main switchboard.

The first month: the induction checklist

One copy per new starter, in the file. Regulation 33 asks that staff receive the induction, training and supervision the role needs; this list is the record. Tick, date and initial each line.

Before the first shift with children

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|--|------------|----------------|
| ☐ Enhanced DBS with barred list check received and recorded (number and date only); Update Service consent noted. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ References received and verified by phone, with the notes in the file. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Safeguarding policy read and signed. The designated officer (LADO) named, with the number. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Whistleblowing: who they can go to, inside and outside the home (RI, LADO, Ofsted), in writing. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Missing child protocol read, and each child's own missing plan. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Behaviour support and restraint policy read. No restraint until trained and signed off. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Medication policy read. No administering until trained and competency assessed. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |

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|--|------------|----------------|
| ☐ Each child's placement plan and risk assessment read and discussed with the key worker. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Fire procedure, health and safety, lone working, and the building walk round. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Recording standards: daily logs, incident reports, what to write and by when. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Confidentiality and data protection, and what never leaves the home. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Complaints procedure, including how a child makes one. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |

In the first month

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|---|------------|----------------|
| ☐ Shadow shifts completed (number agreed and recorded). | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ First supervision held early and recorded on the supervision record (regulation 33(4)). | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Probation review date set and in the diary. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Level 3 diploma: enrolment date agreed and on the Staff list tab. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Mandatory training booked: safeguarding, first aid, fire, medication, physical intervention. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |
| ☐ Introduced to the independent visitor and told what the regulation 44 visit is for. | Date _____ | Initials _____ |

New starter _____

Manager _____

Induction completed on _____